

# Is it possible to train AI in an environmental friendly way?

Posted by u/HauteGina • 0 points • 26 comments

Genuine discussion, I am a CS&CE student but it's something we have never discussed

## Comments

u/SemanticallyInvalid • 1 points • 2026-01-06 14:58 UTC

Today? No

u/Additional\_Boot\_8935 • 1 points • 2026-01-05 18:05 UTC

Enviro concerns are simply a talking point, not an actual concern. Golf courses, restaurants, military bases, all consume significantly more water. The devices and online services you use right now, are already consuming similar amounts of water for their data centers.

What you may want to push for instead is the acceleration of turning non-potable water into potable water. Not only does this fix any faux-enviro-worries, it actually would serve people in far away places that actually are facing a clean water scarcity. Win-win, that's the way to move.

u/Any\_Cow5973 • 1 points • 2026-01-05 20:41 UTC

[https://preview.redd.it/dm80bo76elbg1.jpeg?  
width=640&format=pjpg&auto=webp&s=66c6f627eff3cfa6fb35469b24b930db5d6ca308](https://preview.redd.it/dm80bo76elbg1.jpeg?width=640&format=pjpg&auto=webp&s=66c6f627eff3cfa6fb35469b24b930db5d6ca308)

im sorry you made me do this.

u/Additional\_Boot\_8935 • 1 points • 2026-01-05 21:22 UTC

Only you control yourself, and your pitiful pretend neutral position on the Suno forum was extremely transparent, try harder next time.

[https://preview.redd.it/oty2gdxellbg1.jpeg?  
width=1023&format=pjpg&auto=webp&s=a2bbed4abd5d7a3f4a63efcfb91a3b814379cbe7](https://preview.redd.it/oty2gdxellbg1.jpeg?width=1023&format=pjpg&auto=webp&s=a2bbed4abd5d7a3f4a63efcfb91a3b814379cbe7)

u/Any\_Cow5973 • 1 points • 2026-01-05 21:25 UTC

[https://preview.redd.it/84holba1mlbg1.jpeg?  
width=640&format=pjpg&auto=webp&s=ed25661802ee5e9c6b582809dffe2d9ad83fda63](https://preview.redd.it/84holba1mlbg1.jpeg?width=640&format=pjpg&auto=webp&s=ed25661802ee5e9c6b582809dffe2d9ad83fda63)

u/Extra\_Island7890 • 1 points • 2026-01-05 00:23 UTC

Sort of. We could have a carbon tax (why single out just AI's carbon?) and use part of the tax to plant trees or use other tech to pull carbon from the air. I don't know how high the tax would need to be to make AI carbon neutral. To keep it popular, most of the revenue should go to a UBI.

u/justagenericname213 • 1 points • 2026-01-04 23:48 UTC

Most of the environmental issues AI provably has (total water usage has all sorts of unclear measurements) are local, and largely a consequence of AI datacenters being rushed out as the big companies behind different models race to be the dominant one, without investing in proper infrastructure to support them, or waiting for investments to actually be implemented.

So basically if things were slowed down with the massive scaling up of resources so infrastructure could keep up, it would be a lot less of an issue.

**u/Chuster8888** • 1 points • 2026-01-04 22:52 UTC

see that computer you are using...guess what powers it

**u/Some\_ArabGuy** • 1 points • 2026-01-04 19:15 UTC

Run it on clean energy

Out of everything that harms the environment, AI is not on the priority list, people really need to realise it

And anyways it's just a datacenter, they've existed for ages, should we just get rid of all datacenters? Why doesn't AI get a pass?

**u/sporkyuncle** • 1 points • 2026-01-04 18:27 UTC

AI being trained at all, the way we are currently doing it, is already environmentally friendly, since using AI tends to save energy on tasks compared to doing things the old way. For example, producing a piece of art which is comparable to one which might've taken hours before, hours spent with lights on and the heat on and a PC or tablet continuously powered, and music playing, and the energy spent to feed the human artist (looking up the amount of water a single hamburger uses compared to an AI prompt).

**u/Clear\_University5148** • 1 points • 2026-01-04 16:37 UTC

Unlike inference, training isn't latency-sensitive, so you can do it in remote areas with cheap, renewable energy.

**u/Feroc** • 3 points • 2026-01-04 15:02 UTC

I would argue that almost nothing we do is truly environmentally friendly, as it rarely benefits the environment in a positive way. The best we can do is try to act in a way that minimizes harm.

Then there is the question of how far back you want to trace the supply chain and what kind of models you are referring to. For instance, I have trained LoRAs and we have photovoltaic panels on our roof, so theoretically, I could have trained them using green energy. About 27% of the energy for data centers comes from renewable sources, so theoretically, that could be used to train new models as well. (<https://www.iea.org/reports/energy-and-ai/energy-supply-for-ai>)

Of course, those are just the immediate costs. Hardware must be built, buildings must be constructed and maintained, and all the resources for these things have to be gathered by machines that, again, had to be built somewhere... and so on.

**u/Human\_certified** • 3 points • 2026-01-04 14:37 UTC

There is no reason why it shouldn't be arbitrarily green.

Training a model consumes a certain amount of electrical power, which ends up as heat.

So your four parameters are:

1- How many raw calculations are you doing? (Model parameter size, data size, choice of algorithm, number of epochs....)

\- How efficient is your use of power? (Concentrating everything in data centers is the most efficient by far; a new H200 is a lot more efficient than an old GTX 1080; more RAM/VRAM means less shuffling around of data...)

\- How green is your power mix? (Hydro, geo, solar, wind, nuclear, gas, oil, coal?)

\- How green is your heat removal? (Ambient, air, closed-loop, evaporative, immersion?)

In cooler climates, air cooling works just fine outside of heatwaves. Evaporative cooling is probably the least "green" in the sense that the water use might strain local water usage, but the water is ultimately returned to the water cycle, and it still isn't polluting.

Note that when OpenAI or whoever says "training GPT-something costs \$500 million", they don't mean "\$500 million in electrical power". They mean that they bought hardware and constructed facilities for billions, and that investment is spread out across the various uses. The electricity is a tiny fraction of that cost, <1%.

**u/HauteGina** • 1 points • 2026-01-04 15:03 UTC

this is so interesting, where can I find more data about this and their costs?

**u/manocheese** • 2 points • 2026-01-04 14:15 UTC

I've trained AI models using renewable power, ethically sourced data etc. But the problem with that statement is that I wasn't making anything remotely like ChatGPT, it was a machine learning model trained to recognise emotions in voices. "AI" covers such a wide range of uses that the conversation is far more complicated than most people are willing to get in to.

**u/HauteGina** • 1 points • 2026-01-04 14:18 UTC

you are so right I did not specify LLMs

**u/Slight-Living-8098** • 5 points • 2026-01-04 14:05 UTC

Yes. I trained a couple of my models using a program named EXO that let me network a bunch of Raspberry Pis and old Cell phones for training. They all were powered by a power bank that I ran off my solar panels.

**u/HauteGina** • 1 points • 2026-01-04 14:08 UTC

are you for real?? this sounds so cool

**u/Slight-Living-8098** • 1 points • 2026-01-04 20:03 UTC

Yes, I'm for real. There was also Prime-RL so you can do decentralized training if you and your buddies wanted to team up, or if you have a bunch of older machines you want to have work together.

**u/Infamous\_Campaign687** • 4 points • 2026-01-04 14:03 UTC

Absolutely. It just depends on the location. You can absolutely run the computers on renewable power in a location where water is not a concern. There are many such places in the world.

**u/HauteGina** • 1 points • 2026-01-04 14:08 UTC

how about Italy?

**u/Infamous\_Campaign687** • 1 points • 2026-01-04 17:33 UTC

I'm not an expert on Italian geography but I'd expect the north of Italy to be the only real option. Otherwise lack of water might be a serious issue.